and this lasted for fifty-five days until the legation was relieved by troops of the Eight Nation Alliance which came in from Tianjin. The Alliance consisted of 20,000 troops from the US, Great Britain, France, Germany, Italy, Austria–Hungary, Russia and Japan. The imperial Qing forces were routed while the Boxers melted back into the countryside. There was uncontrolled plunder of the capital by the invading troops and summary executions of Qing soldiers and the Boxer rebels. Unspeakable horrors were visited upon the ordinary people of the city and the surrounding countryside. The scale of the loot carried off by the victorious soldiers and their officers was far greater than the earlier plunder of the Summer Palace in 1860. Fortunes were made from the treasures carried off to the West. Empress Dowager Cixi escaped from Beijing, guarded by loyal troops, and took refuge in the western city of Xian. In the aftermath of this major disaster for the ruling dynasty, the Boxer Protocol of 7 September 1901 was imposed on China by the Eight Nation Alliance, which heaped further indignities and penalties on the ruling dynasty. These included the right of the allies to station troops in Beijing for the safety of their missions and citizens. Yet another large indemnity was imposed on an already bankrupt government, deep in economic crisis. This was a sum of 450 million taels, which in terms of the 2018 price of silver would be US$10 billion. From this point onwards, the decline and demise of China’s longest-ruling dynasty became imminent.

Indian soldiers were the main fighting force under the British and may have participated in the bloody reprisals perpetrated on the hapless Chinese. There are photographs showing Indian soldiers ranged along the steps of the Temple of Heaven. A bronze bell from the temple was brought by the British officers to India and remained with an Indian army regiment as spoils of war. It was returned to China in a goodwill gesture in 1994.

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China’s humiliation did not end with the fall of the Qing dynasty in 1911 and the birth of the Chinese Republic. The Sino-Japanese war of 1936–45 would unleash a fresh round of horrific violence and national humiliation,